



DEPARTMENT OF
RISK & INSURANCE

Tyler Q. Welch
PhD Candidate
4260 Grainger Hall
975 University Avenue
Madison, WI 53706
603-991-6273 | tyler.welch@wisc.edu
<https://www.tqwelch.com>

Professors Rob Hoyt and David Eckles
Department of Insurance, Legal Studies and Real Estate
Terry College of Business
University of Georgia
600 S. Lumpkin Street
Athens, GA 30602

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Dear Professors Hoyt and Eckles,

I am writing to express my strong interest in the tenure-track Assistant Professor position in the Department of Insurance, Legal Studies and Real Estate at the University of Georgia's (UGA) Terry College of Business. I expect to graduate in May 2026.

As a product of risk management and insurance (RMI) programs at both the undergraduate and graduate levels, I have long respected and admired UGA's RMI program. This includes UGA's academic reputation in the American Risk and Insurance Association (ARIA) community. With my educational background, I consider UGA an excellent fit for my research and teaching interests. Having visited UGA twice now, I also consider Athens as an ideal location for the next step in my personal life and career.

My research interests are at the intersection of insurance and public economics. Most of my research focuses on how policymakers, employers, individuals, and insurance markets interact. Centered on one of those interactions, my dissertation focuses on workers' compensation. My job market paper ([link](#)) leverages a unique feature of US workers' compensation insurance markets (relative to other lines of insurance): the competitive, standalone public option which competes with the private market for non-residual risks. Exploiting the formation of several public options in the 1990s, I show that public options lead to more concentrated markets and have little effect on insurer loss ratios, after taking legislated benefit cuts into account.

The other portion of my dissertation focuses on a unique policy in Texas, which allows employers to opt out of providing workers' compensation coverage and, therefore, expose themselves to potential legal liability from employees. To study the Texas setting, I constructed a unique dataset, based on multiple open records requests, that will inspire several future projects. These data include information at both the employer-level, with insurance policy information, and the claim-level within employers. One ongoing project studies how employers make the decision to opt out, focusing on the impacts of insurance premiums (paid by employers that opt in to the workers' compensation system) and increased wages to make up for less in total benefits (paid by employers that opt out of this system).

My published work and other research activities also reflect my interest in the intersection of insurance and public economics. My paper in the *Journal of Health Economics*, for instance, deals with the quality of life expectancy gains across the wealth distribution, informing debates

about the progressivity of old-age insurance provided by Social Security. Another paper, which just received a revise and resubmit request at the *Journal of Risk and Insurance*, focuses on how expansions of health insurance via Medicaid altered incentives to claim Social Security benefits. Another recent paper studies the decumulation patterns of older individuals in the US, decomposing these patterns by asset type, total wealth, and financial literacy. This project recently received a revise-and-resubmit request at the *Geneva Papers on Risk and Insurance – Issues and Practice*. I also serve as a policy consultant at the National Academy of Social Insurance, focused on their workers' compensation work stream, and was a summer fellow at the US Department of Labor's Chief Evaluation Office last year. These roles serve to both strengthen my work and deepen my institutional knowledge, to the benefit of my research agenda.

My research work thus far has also assisted me in developing skills in competing for grants and research awards. While I cannot be a principal investigator (PI) on most grants without a PhD, I helped draft the materials for two large grants. The first was from TIAA, and the resources supported the published paper mentioned above. I have continued to foster connections at TIAA, gauging interest in some new work on older Americans and life insurance that is in progress. The second was a part of the Fall Research Competition at the University of Wisconsin-Madison (UW-Madison) and related to my job market paper. These types of awards not only provide useful support but also serve to expand the reach of my work.

I have been part of two undergraduate RMI programs, as a student at Temple University and now as a Lecturer and Teaching Assistant (TA) at UW-Madison. This has provided me with a deep knowledge of what makes a strong program, and I am sincerely invested in RMI undergraduate education. As such, I have made it a commitment to expand our discipline, from recruiting majors out of introductory RMI classes to assisting students in making industry connections. I would look forward to deepening that commitment at UGA. I am well-equipped to teach an introductory RMI course, having not only taken and taught one myself but also serving as a TA for the introductory course at UW-Madison for four years. During each of those four years, I received a school-wide Distinguished Teaching Award. I also led the main lecture on employee benefits and pension topics. With my RMI educational background, I feel prepared to teach other courses related to property-liability and life insurance, employee benefits, insurance operations, and corporate risk management.

With my application, I am submitting my curriculum vitae, a statement on my teaching philosophy (with evidence), a research statement (with links to completed and working papers), and contact information for three references. I am happy to provide any additional information.

I greatly appreciate your time and thank you for your consideration of my application. I look forward to hearing from you.

Sincerely,

Tyler Q. Welch